DAILY ACTIVE RECALL · MASTER MATRIX & FACTS

INDIAN ART & CULTURE

भारतीय कला एवं संस्कृति — उच्च-प्राथमिकता पुनरावलोकन

8 Classical Dances, Classical Languages, Temple Architecture (Nagara, Dravida, Vesara), UNESCO World Heritage Sites, GI Tags, Folk Paintings, and Cultural Institutions.

- **High-Yield Ratta Matrix**
  Concentrated prelims facts, tables & comparisons
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  Confused pairs and high-frequency exam traps
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  Formulated for active morning memory drills
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  Curated strictly for UPPSC Prelims, RO/ARO & BEO

UP-PCS & UK-PCS Examination Resource
General Studies Paper 1 · Prelims Fast-Recall Desk

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★ UPPCS & UKPCS Prelims Comprehensive Revision & Active Recall Master Sheet

Exam Focus: UPPSC Prelims (Paper 1), UKPSC Prelims (Paper 1), RO/ARO, BEO
Frequency: Daily morning read (15–20 minutes)
Syllabus Areas Covered: The 8 Classical Dances with states, pioneers, and exponents; Classical Languages criteria and all 11 recognized languages; Nagara, Dravida, and Vesara architectural styles with masterpiece temples; All 45 UNESCO Tangible World Heritage Sites and all 16 Intangible Cultural Heritage (ICH) elements; Fairs and festivals of India, Uttar Pradesh, and Uttarakhand; Traditional Indian folk paintings, folk theatres, and puppetry traditions; Martial arts of India; Hindustani classical music gharanas and prominent exponents; Prominent Geographical Indication (GI) tags of Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand.

1. The 8 Classical Dances of India (Recognized by Sangeet Natak Akademi)

Dance Form	State of Origin	Key Pioneers & Revivalists	Notable Exponents	Distinctive Features, Repertoire & Exam Keywords
Bharatanatyam	**Tamil Nadu**	**E. Krishna Iyer**, **Rukmini Devi Arundale** (founder of Kalakshetra Foundation)	Yamini Krishnamurthy, Padma Subrahmanyam, Alarmel Valli, Mrinalini Sarabhai	Regarded as the **oldest classical dance** of India, originating from ancient temple dancer (*Devadasi*) traditions where it was historically known as *Sadir* or *Dasi Attam*. It symbolizes the element of fire (*Agni*) and features the characteristic half-sitting stance termed **Araimandi**. A complete traditional recital follows the structured sequence: *Alarippu* → *Jatiswaram* → *Shabdam* → *Varnam* → *Padam* → *Tillana*. It is performed in the *Ekaharya* format, wherein a single performer assumes and portrays multiple roles.
Kathak	**Uttar Pradesh**	**Lady Leela Sokhey** (Madame Menaka), **Nawab Wajid Ali Shah** (patron of Lucknow Gharana)	**Pt. Birju Maharaj**, Sitara Devi, Shambhu Maharaj, Lachhu Maharaj, Damayanti Joshi	The name derives from the ancient aphorism *"Katha Kahe So Kathak Kahave"* (one who recites stories is a Kathak). The dance is characterized by intricate and swift rhythmic footwork (**Tatkar**), dazzling pirouettes (**Chakkars**), expressive gait narratives (*Gat Nikas*), and dynamic rhythmic contests (*Jugalbandi*) with the tabla. Its major gharanas include **Lucknow** (famed for grace, *Bhava*, and subtle mime), **Jaipur** (distinguished by fiery footwork, speed, and *Veer rasa*), **Banaras**, and **Raigarh**.
Kathakali	**Kerala**	**Vallathol Narayana Menon** (founder of Kerala Kalamandalam)	Kalamandalam Gopi, Guru Kunchu Kurup, Raman Kutty Nair	A grand visual dance-drama enacting epic narratives from the Ramayana and Mahabharata. It is celebrated for its elaborate facial makeup (*Chutti*) and ornate towering headgear. Character types are defined by strict symbolic facial colors: **Pacha** (green makeup, depicting divine heroes and noble kings), **Kathi** (knife-shaped red streaks on green with a white nose-knob, representing arrogant royalty and villains), **Thadi** (bearded characters: red/black for evil demons, white for pious figures like Hanuman), and **Minukku** (warm yellow/flesh tone, representing virtuous women and sages).

Dance Form	State of Origin	Key Pioneers & Revivalists	Notable Exponents	Distinctive Features, Repertoire & Exam Keywords
Kuchipudi	**Andhra Pradesh**	**Siddhendra Yogi** (creator of *Bhamakalapam*)	Yamini Krishnamurthy, Raja & Radha Reddy, Swapnasundari	Named after its village of origin, Kuchelapuram in Krishna district, this form developed as a dance-drama tradition combining spoken dialogue, classical singing, and dance. Its most celebrated virtuoso feature is the **Tarangam**, in which the dancer deftly balances upon the raised rim of a brass plate while carrying a brass water pitcher (*Kundi*) balanced steadily atop the head.
Odissi	**Odisha**	**Kelucharan Mohapatra**, Pankaj Charan Das, Deba Prasad Das	Sonal Mansingh, Sanjukta Panigrahi, Madhavi Mudgal	Deeply rooted in temple rituals, its lineage traces back to female temple dancers (*Maharis*) and juvenile male performers (*Gotipuas*). The performance repertoire is heavily inspired by Jayadeva's devotional masterpiece, the *Gita Govinda*. It is distinguished by two fundamental body postures: the feminine, soft, three-bend deflective stance (**Tribhanga**) and the firm, square, masculine stance (**Chowk**).
Sattriya	**Assam**	**Mahapurusha Srimanta Sankardeva** (15th century)	Bhabananda Barbayan, Jatin Goswami, Ghanakanta Bora	Created as an instrument of the Neo-Vaishnavite Bhakti movement, this sacred dance form was nurtured for over five centuries inside monastic sanctuaries known as **Sattras**. Its musical and theatrical foundation rests upon *Borgeet* (devotional songs) and *Ankiya Nat* (one-act devotional plays). The Sangeet Natak Akademi officially recognized Sattriya as India's 8th classical dance in **November 2000**.
Manipuri	**Manipur**	**King Bhagyachandra** (Ningthou Ching-Thang Khomba), **Rabindranath Tagore** (introduced at Santiniketan)	Guru Bipin Singh, Jhaveri Sisters (Nayna, Suvarna, Darshana, Ranjana), Charu Mathur	Centered upon the immortal, tender love of Radha and Krishna through devotional **Raslila** performances. It is distinguished by soft, undulating, lyrical movements in which the dancer's feet never strike the floor sharply. Female dancers wear an ornate, stiff cylindrical skirt known as the **Potloi** or *Kumin*. Performances are traditionally complemented by the energetic, acrobatic drum dance called **Pung Cholom**.
Mohiniyattam	**Kerala**	**Maharaja Swathi Thirunal** of Travancore, **Vallathol Narayana Menon**	Sunanda Nair, Bharati Shivaji, Kanak Rele, Gopika Varma	Literally meaning the "Dance of the Enchantress", this dance draws mythological inspiration from Lord Vishnu's Mohini incarnation. It is performed strictly as a solo feminine recital embodying pure **Lasya** (delicate, wave-like, swaying body movements resembling palm fronds). Performers are clad in a signature pristine off-white handloom saree embellished with a shimmering golden brocade border, known as the **Kasavu saree**.

2. Classical Languages of India (Chronology & Criteria)

A. Chronological Order of Recognition

1. **Tamil** (Declared in **2004**) — Conferred status as India's first Classical Language.
2. **Sanskrit** (Declared in **2005**).
3. **Telugu** (Declared in **2008**).
4. **Kannada** (Declared in **2008**).
5. **Malayalam** (Declared in **2013**).

6. **Odia** (Declared in **2014**).
7. **Marathi** (Approved by the Union Cabinet on **3 October 2024**).
8. **Pali** (Approved on **3 October 2024**).
9. **Prakrit** (Approved on **3 October 2024**).
10. **Assamese** (Approved on **3 October 2024**).
11. **Bengali** (Approved on **3 October 2024**).

(India officially recognizes 11 Classical Languages following the landmark Union Cabinet decision of October 2024.)

B. Eligibility Criteria (Ministry of Culture)

To qualify for status as a Classical Language, a language must satisfy the following four criteria formulated by the Ministry of Culture: - **High Antiquity:** Recorded history and early literary texts spanning a historical antiquity of **1500 to 2000 years**. - **Valuable Heritage:** A treasured corpus of ancient literature and texts cherished as invaluable heritage by generations of speakers. - **Original Literary Tradition:** A literary heritage that is demonstrably authentic and original, not borrowed from another speech community. - **Linguistic Distinctiveness:** A distinct divergence between the classical language and its modern forms or vernacular offshoots, acknowledging potential historical discontinuity across later evolutionary stages.

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3. Temple Architecture Styles & Architectural Anatomy

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│                  NAGARA vs DRAVIDA ARCHITECTURE              │
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│ NAGARA (North Indian Style)      │ DRAVIDA (South Indian Style)  │
├──────────────────────────────────┼───────────────────────────┤
│ • Curvilinear tower: Shikhara    │ • Stepped-pyramidal tower: Vimana  │
│ • Crowning Amalaka & Kalasha     │ • Crowning octagonal/dome Stupika  │
│ • Built on a raised plinth: Jagati│ • Enclosed by elaborate boundary wall│
│ • Monumental gateways absent     │ • Towering ornamental gates: Gopuram│
│ • Temple water tanks not mandatory│ • Temple water tank (Kalyani) inside│
│ • Sub-types: Rekha-Deula, Phamsana│ • Multi-pillared assembly Mandapas  │
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A. Core Architectural Vocabulary

- **Garbhagriha (Sanctum Sanctorum):** The innermost, unadorned sacred chamber housing the principal deity, designed to focus divine energy.
- **Mandapa:** A pillared hall situated in front of the sanctum, serving as a gathering space for devotees during rituals.
- **Antarala (Vestibule):** An intermediate foyer or transit vestibule connecting the Garbhagriha with the main Mandapa.
- **Shikhara (North) / Vimana (South):** The monumental mountain-like spire rising skyward directly over the Garbhagriha.
- **Amalaka:** A large, fluted circular stone disc resembling a myrobalan fruit, installed at the apex of a Nagara Shikhara.
- **Kalasha:** A pot- or pitcher-shaped decorative finial placed directly atop the Amalaka as the highest point of the temple.
- **Gopuram:** A towering, monumental gateway providing entrance through the perimeter walls of South Indian Dravidian temple complexes.
- **Panchayatana Style:** An architectural layout where the main central shrine is symmetrically flanked by **four smaller subsidiary shrines** at the corners (prominent examples include the Dashavatara Temple at Deogarh, and the Kandariya Mahadeva and Lakshmana temples at Khajuraho).

B. Masterpiece Temples, Dynasties & Architectural Highlights

Temple Name	Location	Builder Dynasty & Ruler	Architectural Style & Primary Exam Significance
Kailasa Temple (Cave 16)	Ellora (Maharashtra)	**Krishna I** (Rashtrakuta Dynasty, 8th century CE)	Celebrated as the **world's largest monolithic rock-cut monument**, excavated vertically from top to bottom out of a single volcanic basalt cliff face.

Temple Name	Location	Builder Dynasty & Ruler	Architectural Style & Primary Exam Significance
Shore Temple	Mamallapuram (Tamil Nadu)	**Narasimhavarman II Rajasimha** (Pallava Dynasty)	One of the earliest free-standing structural stone temples in Southern India, built on the edge of the Bay of Bengal; designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
Brihadeshwara (Rajarajeshwara)	Thanjavur (Tamil Nadu)	**Rajaraja I Chola** (consecrated in 1010 CE)	Represents the zenith of Dravida architecture, crowned by a massive 66-metre pyramidal Vimana and an 80-tonne monolithic granite Stupika; renowned for its shadow engineering.
Gangaikonda Cholapuram	Ariyalur (Tamil Nadu)	**Rajendra I Chola** (1035 CE)	Commissioned to commemorate Rajendra I's victorious military campaign to the holy River Ganga; features a graceful, concave-curving Vimana profile.
Sun Temple	Konark (Odisha)	**Narasimhadeva I** (Eastern Ganga Dynasty, 13th century CE)	Designed in the form of an immense stone chariot dedicated to the Sun God Surya, complete with 24 carved stone wheels and 7 galloping horses; historically termed the **"Black Pagoda"**.
Jagannath Temple	Puri (Odisha)	**Anantavarman Chodaganga** (Eastern Ganga Dynasty)	A quintessential monument of the Kalinga Nagara style (Rekha-Deula); celebrated for the world-famous Ratha Yatra and historically known as the **"White Pagoda"**.
Lingaraja Temple	Bhubaneswar (Odisha)	Somavamshi Dynasty (King Yayati I)	Regarded as the most complete and magnificent specimen of Kalinga architecture, showcasing all four classic halls: Deula, Jagamohana, Natamandapa, and Bhogamandapa.
Sun Temple	Modhera (Gujarat)	**Bhima I** (Solanki / Chaulukya Dynasty, 1026 CE)	Built in the ornate Maru-Gurjara style; renowned for its grand stepped water tank (**Surya Kund**) adorned with 108 miniature shrines along its terraces.
Kandariya Mahadeva Temple	Khajuraho (Madhya Pradesh)	**Dhangadeva / Vidyadhara** (Chandela Dynasty, 10th–11th century CE)	The largest and most elaborate Hindu temple at Khajuraho; erected on a Panchayatana plan with a soaring Shikhara accompanied by 84 subsidiary spires (*Urushringas*).
Dilwara Jain Temples	Mount Abu (Rajasthan)	**Vimal Shah** (Vimal Vasahi, 1031 CE) & **Tejpala / Vastupala** (Luna Vasahi, 1230 CE)	Outstanding examples of Solanki temple craft, internationally famous for their luminous, translucent white marble ceiling carvings and filigree stonework.
Hoysaleswara Temple	Halebidu (Karnataka)	King Vishnuvardhana (Hoysala Dynasty)	Carved from soft chloritic schist (soapstone) on a stellate (star-shaped) plinth, covered in intricate, continuous narrative friezes; inscribed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2023.
Chennakeshava Temple	Belur (Karnataka)	King Vishnuvardhana (Hoysala Dynasty, 1117 CE)	Built to commemorate Hoysala military triumphs; celebrated for its star-shaped sanctum and masterfully sculpted *Madanika* bracket figures; inscribed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2023.
Dashavatara Temple	Deogarh (Lalitpur district, UP)	Gupta Period (6th century CE)	Stands as the **earliest surviving Panchayatana stone temple in Northern India**, famous for its classical relief depiction of Sheshashayi Vishnu reclining on the serpent Shesha.
Bhitargaon Temple	Kanpur district (UP)	Gupta Period (5th century CE; Gupta imperial span c. 320–550 CE)	Recognized as the **oldest surviving terracotta and brick temple** in India featuring a genuine radiating structural arch.

Dynastic Spans for Key Temple Builders: Gupta Empire (c. 320–550 CE: Deogarh, Bhitargaon); Imperial Pallavas (c. 575–897 CE: Shore Temple under Rajasimha); Rashtrakutas (c. 753–973 CE: Kailasa Temple under Krishna I); Imperial Cholas (c. 850–1279 CE: Rajaraja I in 1010 CE, Rajendra I in 1035 CE); Chandelas of Jejakabhukti (c. 9th–13th century CE: Khajuraho); Eastern Gangas (c. 11th–15th century CE: Konark, Puri); Hoysalas (c. 11th–14th century CE: Belur in 1117 CE, Halebidu); Solankis / Chaulukyas of Gujarat (c. 10th–13th century CE: Modhera in 1026 CE).

4. Fairs and Festivals of India, Uttar Pradesh & Uttarakhand

A. Major National Cultural Festivals

- **Hornbill Festival (Nagaland):** Held annually from 1 to 10 December at the Naga Heritage Village in Kisama; acclaimed as the "Festival of Festivals", it showcases the collective traditions of all 16 recognized Naga tribes.
- **Bihu (Assam):** Celebrated across three distinct agricultural cycles: *Rongali (Bohag) Bihu* in spring (April) marking the Assamese New Year, *Kongali (Kati) Bihu* in autumn marking crop protection, and *Bhogali (Magh) Bihu* in winter marking the post-harvest feast.
- **Chapchar Kut (Mizoram):** Celebrated with great joy in spring after the completion of jhum (slash-and-burn) clearing operations; famously features the traditional *Cheraw* bamboo dance.
- **Losar (Ladakh, Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh):** The traditional Buddhist and Tibetan New Year festival, observed with monastic mask dances (*Cham*) and elaborate symbolic offerings.
- **Pushkar Fair (Ajmer, Rajasthan):** One of the world's largest livestock and camel trading fairs, organized during Kartik Purnima along the holy banks of Lake Pushkar.
- **Thrissur Pooram (Kerala):** Staged at the Vadakkunnathan Temple in Thrissur; renowned for competitive temple displays featuring caparisoned elephants, dynamic parasol exchanges (*Kudamattam*), and majestic traditional percussion ensembles (*Panchavadyam*).
- **Wangala Festival (Garo Hills, Meghalaya):** Known as the "100 Drum Festival", this post-harvest celebration is observed by the Garo tribe in honor of Saljong, the Sun God of fertility.

B. Uttar Pradesh Fairs & Festivals (High-Yield State Core)

- **Kumbh Mela & Magh Mela (Prayagraj):** Organized at the sacred Triveni Sangam (confluence of the Ganga, Yamuna, and mythical Saraswati); the Maha Kumbh takes place every 12 years, with the annual Magh Mela held during the Hindu month of Magha.
- **Bateshwar Fair (Bateshwar, Agra):** A renowned historic cattle and livestock fair hosted along the Yamuna riverbank, famous for its picturesque riverside cluster of 101 Shiva temples.
- **Nauchandi Mela (Meerut):** A celebrated symbol of communal fraternity held after Holi, where pilgrims pay homage concurrently to the shrine of Nav Chandi Devi and the dargah of Sufi saint Hazrat Bale Miyan.
- **Shakumbhari Devi Mela (Saharanpur):** Organized twice every year during the auspicious Chaitra and Ashwin Navratris at the historic Shakumbhari Devi Peeth in the Shivalik foothills.
- **Devi Patan Mela (Tulsipur, Balrampur):** A major annual fair held at the sacred Devi Patan Shaktipeeth, deeply revered across the Indo-Nepal Terai region.
- **Dadri Mela (Ballia):** Regarded as India's second-largest cattle fair, historically established and named in commemoration of the revered sage Dardar Muni.
- **Govardhan Parikrama & Lathmar Holi (Mathura, Barsana & Nandgaon):** Centuries-old Braj traditions featuring circumambulation of the sacred Govardhan Hill and the joyous playful stick-and-shield Holi celebrations between the women of Barsana and the men of Nandgaon.
- **Taj Mahotsav (Agra):** A vibrant 10-day cultural extravaganza organized each February at Shilpgram near the Taj Mahal, highlighting Mughal crafts, culinary arts, and folk performances.
- **Sulh-i-Kul Festival (Agra):** Inspired by Emperor Akbar’s imperial principle of universal peace and religious tolerance (*Sulh-i-Kul*), this festival serves as a cornerstone of interfaith unity.

C. Uttarakhand Fairs & Festivals (UKPCS Priority)

- **Nanda Devi Raj Jat (Chamoli, Uttarakhand):** Organized **once every 12 years**, this epic 280-kilometre barefoot pilgrimage spans from Nauti village to the sacred lake of Homkund at the base of Mount Trishul, led by a sacred four-horned ram (**Chasingha Khadu**).
- **Ramman (Saloor-Dungra village, Joshimath, Chamoli):** A ritualistic religious festival and folk theatre dedicated to the tutelary deity **Bhumiyal Devta**; features masked dances utilizing traditional painted wooden masks and has been inscribed on UNESCO's Intangible Cultural Heritage list.
- **Bagwal Mela / Stone-Throwing Fair (Devidhura, Champawat):** Celebrated annually on Raksha Bandhan at the Maa Varahi Devi Temple, where warriors of four local clans (*Khams*) traditionally engage in stone-hurling ritual combat.
- **Purnagiri Mela (Tanakpur, Champawat):** Attracts hundreds of thousands of devotees during Chaitra Navratri to the Purnagiri Shaktipeeth perched above the Sharda (Kali) River.
- **Uttarayani Mela (Bageshwar):** Celebrated on Makar Sankranti at the holy confluence of the Saryu and Gomati rivers; carries immense modern historical importance as the site where registers of the oppressive Coolie-Begar forced labor system were dumped into the river in 1921.
- **Jaiti Mela (Almora):** A traditional cultural fair of the Kumaon region, featuring spirited performances of the circular *Jhora* dance and traditional folk ballads.

5. UNESCO Tangible World Heritage Sites in India (45 Total Sites)

India currently possesses 45 inscribed UNESCO World Heritage Sites following the historic inscription of Sarnath in July 2026.

- **The Sole Mixed Heritage Site: Khangchendzonga National Park** (Sikkim, inscribed in 2016 for combined natural and cultural criteria).
- **Latest Landmark Inscriptions:**
- **#45: Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath (Uttar Pradesh)** — Inscribed in **July 2026** at the 48th World Heritage Committee session in Busan. This serial cultural site encompasses the monumental **Chaukhandi Stupa** together with the excavated core remains including the Dhamek Stupa and Ashokan pillar sanctuary. It represents **Uttar Pradesh's 4th cultural World Heritage Site**.
- **#44: Maratha Military Landscapes of India** (Inscribed in **2025**; covers 12 historic fortifications: 11 in Maharashtra and Gingee Fort in Tamil Nadu).
- **#43: Moidams – Mound-Burial System of the Ahom Dynasty** (Charaideo district, Assam, inscribed in **2024**).
- **#42: Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas** (Karnataka — Belur, Halebidu, and Somnathpura, inscribed in **2023**).
- **#41: Santiniketan** (Birbhum district, West Bengal, inscribed in **2023**).
- **#40: Dholavira: A Harappan City** (Kutch district, Gujarat, inscribed in **2021**).
- **#39: Kakatiya Rudreshwara / Ramappa Temple** (Palampet, Mulugu district, Telangana, inscribed in **2021**).
- **Uttar Pradesh Tangible Cultural World Heritage Sites (4 Sites):**
- **Taj Mahal** (Agra — inscribed in 1983)
- **Agra Fort** (Agra — inscribed in 1983)
- **Fatehpur Sikri** (Agra — inscribed in 1986)
- **Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath** (Varanasi district — inscribed in **2026**)
- **Uttarakhand Tangible Natural World Heritage Site (1 Serial Property):**
- **Nanda Devi and Valley of Flowers National Parks** (Chamoli district, inscribed in 1988, expanded in 2005).

> **Important Distinction:** In examination questions, do not quote obsolete counts of 42 or 43 sites, nor limit Uttar Pradesh to only 3 tangible sites following the 2026 inscription of Sarnath. Furthermore, note that the inclusion of **Deepavali** (December 2025) belongs to UNESCO's **Intangible Cultural Heritage (ICH)** list, which is entirely distinct from physical World Heritage monuments.

6. Important Geographical Indications (GI Tags) of UP & UK

State	Product Name & Craft	Category	Distinctive Origin District & Significance
Uttar Pradesh	**Banaras Brocades and Sarees**	Handicraft	Varanasi; renowned globally for rich gold and silver (*Zari*) brocade handloom weaving.
	Bhadohi Handmade Carpet	Handicraft	Bhadohi (Mirzapur-Bhadohi carpet manufacturing belt); premier woollen hand-knotted carpets.
	Lucknow Chikan Craft	Handicraft	Lucknow; centuries-old delicate white-on-white hand embroidery patronized by Awadh Nawabs.
	Kannauj Perfume (Attar)	Manufactured	Kannauj; acclaimed as the "Perfume Capital of India", distilling natural floral attar in copper stills.
	Moradabad Metal Craft	Handicraft	Moradabad; widely celebrated as *Peetal Nagari* (Brass City) for ornate engraved brassware.
	Firozabad Glassware	Handicraft	Firozabad; known as *Suhag Nagari*, the historic hub of India's glass bangle and glassware industry.
	Aligarh Locks	Manufactured	Aligarh; traditionally designated as *Tala Nagari* (City of Locks) for precision brass and iron locks.
	Gorakhpur Terracotta	Handicraft	Gorakhpur; traditional reddish clay craftsmanship producing distinctive elephant and horse figurines.
	Kalanamak Rice	Agriculture	Siddhartha Nagar and surrounding Terai districts; aromatic black-husked rice associated with Lord Buddha.
	Mahoba Gaura Patthar Hastashilp	Handicraft	Mahoba (Bundelkhand); delicate carving in soft, radiant white pyrophyllite stone.
Uttarakhand	**Berinag Tea**	Agriculture	Pithoragarh district; exquisite, aromatic orthodox Himalayan tea made from wild and cultivated bush leaves.
	Almora Bal Mithai	Food Stuff	Almora; iconic roasted fudge-like sweet made from condensed milk (*khoya*), coated with white sugar globules.
	Uttarakhand Bhotia Dan	Handicraft	Pithoragarh and Chamoli; dense, hand-knotted traditional woollen floor rugs woven by Bhotia tribal women.
	Munsyari White Rajma	Agriculture	Munsyari (Pithoragarh); high-altitude organic kidney beans prized for delicate texture and swift cooking.
	Uttarakhand Ringal Craft	Handicraft	Chamoli and Garhwal hills; flexible Himalayan dwarf bamboo (*Ringal*) woven into baskets, mats, and wares.
	Uttarakhand Aipan Art	Handicraft	Kumaon region; sacred ritual geometric floor and wall art painted with white rice paste over red ochre.
	Uttarakhand Bichhu Buti (Nettle Fabric)	Textile	Chamoli district; eco-friendly natural fiber extracted from wild Himalayan stinging nettle (*Girardinia diversifolia*).
	Jhangora & Manduwa	Agriculture	Mountain districts of Uttarakhand; highly nutritious traditional hill millets (Barnyard Millet and Finger Millet).

7. Folk Paintings of India — State-Wise Master Guide

Traditional Painting Form	State / Region	Key Features, Media & Cultural Significance
Sanjhi	**Uttar Pradesh** (Mathura–Vrindavan / Braj)	An exquisite traditional stencilled **paper-cutting art** practiced along the Yamuna ghats of Mathura and Vrindavan. Traditionally fashioned during Krishna festivals and Pitru Paksha; recognized with an official GI tag.
Aipan	**Uttarakhand** (Kumaon)	A sacred ritual floor and wall art created using white rice-flour paste (*Biswar*) upon an ochre-red background (*Geru*), featuring complex geometric and floral protective motifs. Holds a GI tag.
Madhubani (Mithila Painting)	**Bihar** (Mithila region)	Practiced traditionally by women using natural pigments and brushes made of twigs and nibs; characterized by vivid double-line borders and stylized motifs of deities, nature, and the wedding chamber (*Kohbar*). Holds a GI tag.
Warli	**Maharashtra** (Thane / Palghar)	An ancient tribal art executed on mud-and-cowdung plastered walls using white pigment made of rice paste and water, depicting community dancing, harvesting, and reverence for the mother goddess *Palaghata*.
Pattachitra	**Odisha** (also practiced in West Bengal)	A traditional scroll painting executed on treated cloth (*Patta*) or dried palm leaves using natural mineral colors, illustrating episodes from the life of Lord Jagannath, Krishna, and Vaishnava legends.
Phad	**Rajasthan** (Bhilwara / Shahpura)	Immense narrative cloth scroll paintings depicting the heroic exploits of folk deities such as Pabuji and Devnarayan, traditionally recited and sung by traveling priest-bards (*Bhopas*).
Gond	**Madhya Pradesh** (Mandla / Dindori)	Celebrated tribal art of the Gond community, characterized by rich textures composed of fine dots, dashes, and rhythmic lines, depicting flora, fauna, and their supreme forest divinity *Bada Dev*.
Kalamkari	**Andhra Pradesh**	Traditional hand-painted and block-printed textile art using natural vegetable dyes and a sharpened bamboo reed (*kalam*). Maintained through two prominent traditions: **Srikalahasti** (freehand temple hangings depicting epics) and **Machilipatnam** (block-printed trade designs).
Pithora	**Gujarat & Madhya Pradesh** (Rathwa & Bhil tribes)	Sacred ritual wall paintings executed inside tribal homes to invoke prosperity and fulfill vows, centered on the consecrated depiction of horses honoring the deity *Pithora Baba*.
Kalighat	**West Bengal** (Kolkata)	A 19th-century urban folk painting style that developed around the Kalighat Kali Temple, renowned for sweeping brush lines and watercolor washes depicting Hindu divinities and satirical caricatures of the colonial elite.
Phulkari	**Punjab**	Traditional folk floral embroidery executed on coarse dyed cotton cloth (*khaddar*) using vibrant untwisted silk threads (*pat*), traditionally gifted during weddings.
Mandana	**Rajasthan & Malwa**	Auspicious geometric floor and wall designs drawn with white chalk (*khadiya*) against red clay plaster to welcome deities and mark domestic festivals.

> **Key Exam Distinction:** Do not confuse **Sanjhi** (indigenous to the Braj region of Uttar Pradesh), **Aipan** (traditional to Kumaon in Uttarakhand), and **Madhubani** (native to Bihar). Each holds a distinct geographical and cultural identity.

8. All 16 UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage (ICH) Elements of India

Inscribed on the Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity (Ministry of Culture & UNESCO):

#	Year Inscribed	Intangible Cultural Heritage Element	Region / Community	Primary Ritual & Cultural Significance
1	**2008**	**Koodiyattam (Kutiyattam)**	**Kerala**	India's oldest living Sanskrit temple theatre tradition, performed in consecrated theatre halls called *Koothambalams* with the accompaniment of copper *Mizhavu* drums.
2	**2008**	**Ramlila**	**Uttar Pradesh & North India**	The traditional dramatic enactment of the Ramayana during Dussehra, epitomized by the world-famous month-long open-air Ramnagar Ramlila of Varanasi supported by the Kashi Naresh.
3	**2008**	**Tradition of Vedic Chanting**	Pan-India	The uninterrupted oral recitation of sacred Vedic hymns handed down over millennia through sophisticated mnemonic recitation techniques such as *Jatapatha* and *Ghanapatha*.
4	**2009**	**Ramman**	**Saloor-Dungra village, Chamoli (Uttarakhand)**	A ritual festival and sacred masked theatre held in honor of the tutelary deity **Bhumiyal Devta**, where villagers perform epic episodes wearing traditional wooden masks.
5	**2010**	**Chhau Dance**	**Jharkhand, West Bengal, Odisha**	A semi-classical martial dance tradition that encompasses three distinct regional streams: **Seraikella** (Jharkhand, masked), **Purulia** (West Bengal, large theatrical masks), and **Mayurbhanj** (Odisha, performed without masks).
6	**2010**	**Kalbelia Folk Songs and Dances**	**Rajasthan**	A sensuous, serpent-like folk dance performed by women of the nomadic Kalbelia snake-charmer community, rhythmically driven by the *Poongi* (been) and *Dhaf*.
7	**2010**	**Mudiyettu**	**Kerala**	A sacred ritual dance-drama performed in Kali temples, dramatizing the mythological battle between the goddess Kali and the demon Darika; preceded by elaborate floor paintings called *Kalam*.
8	**2012**	**Buddhist Chanting of Ladakh**	**Ladakh (Trans-Himalaya)**	The solemn rhythmic chanting of sacred Buddhist texts and philosophical teachings by Mahayana monks (Lamas) of the Gelukpa, Drukpa, and Kagyu monastic lineages.
9	**2013**	**Sankirtana**	**Manipur**	A sacred ritual performance encompassing devotional singing, drumming (*Pung*), and graceful dance, performed by Meitei Vaishnavites to mark life-cycle ceremonies and religious festivals.
10	**2014**	**Traditional Brass and Copper Craft of Utensil Making**	**Jandiala Guru, Amritsar (Punjab)**	The artisanal metal-working technique of hammering heated brass and copper plates into household vessels, practiced traditionally by the hereditary **Thathera** community.
11	**2016**	**Yoga**	Pan-India (Global)	The ancient Indian physical, mental, and spiritual discipline founded upon Patanjali's Ashtanga Yoga; commemorated internationally each year on **21 June**.
12	**2016**	**Nawrouz (Nowruz)**	Parsi & Kashmiri communities	The ancient Persian New Year festival celebrated annually on the vernal equinox (**21 March**), signifying renewal, peace, and the rebirth of nature.
13	**2017**	**Kumbh Mela**	**Prayagraj (UP), Haridwar (UK), Ujjain (MP), Nashik (Maharashtra)**	The largest peaceful religious gathering of pilgrims on Earth, rotating across four sacred river sanctuaries (Ganga, Godavari, and Kshipra) over twelve-year cycles.

#	Year Inscribed	Intangible Cultural Heritage Element	Region / Community	Primary Ritual & Cultural Significance
14	**2021**	**Durga Puja in Kolkata**	**Kolkata (West Bengal)**	A monumental 10-day autumn festival celebrating the triumph of Goddess Durga over Mahishasura, renowned for extraordinary public art installations, community pandals, and syncretic celebrations.
15	**2023**	**Garba of Gujarat**	**Gujarat**	A devotional, circular community dance performed during the nine nights of Navratri around a perforated earthen lamp (*Garbha Deep*) or an image of Goddess Amba.
16	**2025 (Dec)**	**Deepavali (Festival of Lights)**	Pan-India	Inscribed at the 20th session of the Intergovernmental Committee in December 2025 as India's 16th ICH element, honoring the universal celebration of light over darkness and wisdom over ignorance.

9. Traditional Folk Theatres & Puppetry of India

A. Major Folk Theatres

Folk Theatre Form	State / Region	Key Features, Dramaturgy & Musical Accompaniment
Nautanki	**Uttar Pradesh**	Highly popular operatic folk musical theatre of Northern India; evolved two renowned styles: **Hathras** (emphasizing classical singing) and **Kanpur** (noted for crisp theatrical dialogue). Plays feature verses in *Doha, Chaubola*, and *Chhand* meters accompanied by the thunderous **Nakkara** (kettledrum).
Bhand Pather	**Jammu & Kashmir**	Traditional satirical folk theatre practiced by rural farming communities; blends witty social criticism, parodies, and slapstick comedy with music played on the *Surnai* (shehnai-like reed) and *Dhol*.
Swang / Saang	**Haryana & Western UP**	Dialogue-driven musical folk drama written in rhymed verse; pioneered by celebrated playwrights such as Pt. Deep Chand and Kishan Lal Bhat; staged on open platforms surrounded by spectators.
Rasleela & Ramlila	**Uttar Pradesh** (Mathura–Vrindavan & Ayodhya / Varanasi)	Devotional dance-dramas dramatizing the divine childhood pastimes of Lord Krishna in Braj and the heroic life journey of Lord Rama across Awadh and Varanasi.
Bhavai	**Gujarat & Rajasthan**	Fast-paced socio-religious folk theatre initiated by the 14th-century poet Asaita Thakar; features male actors balancing up to eight earthen pots on their heads while playing the long brass trumpet known as the **Bhungal**.
Jatra	**West Bengal & Odisha**	Open-air musical melodrama that emerged during the Bhakti movement under Chaitanya Mahaprabhu; characterized by grand musical prologues, impassioned dialogues, and high dramatic intensity.
Yakshagana	**Karnataka** (Coastal)	Spectacular traditional theatre based on episodes from the Hindu epics; distinguished by elaborate costumes, towering decorated headdresses (**Muguta**), vivid facial cosmetics, and high athletic leaps.
Therukoothu	**Tamil Nadu**	Traditional rural street theatre performed in village squares, historically centered on the annual festival worship of Draupadi Amman.
Koodiyattam	**Kerala**	Classical Sanskrit temple drama recognized as a UNESCO ICH masterpiece; features stylized hand gestures (*Mudras*) and highly sophisticated eye movements accompanied by *Mizhavu* drums.

Folk Theatre Form	State / Region	Key Features, Dramaturgy & Musical Accompaniment
Ankiya Nat / Bhaona	**Assam**	One-act Vaishnavite devotional plays created by **Srimanta Sankardeva**; composed in the literary language *Brajavali* and traditionally staged in monastic assembly halls (**Namghars**).
Tamasha	**Maharashtra**	Energetic, fast-paced secular folk theatre that evolved in military camps; combines satirical comedy, witty banter, and lively *Lavani* dance accompanied by the *Dholki*.
Dashavatar	**Konkan / Goa / Maharashtra**	Traditional temple folk theatre depicting the ten divine incarnations of Lord Vishnu, widely performed during local harvest festivities.

B. Traditional Indian Puppetry (Four Master Traditions)

Puppetry Form	Traditional Name	State of Origin	Key Construction & Manipulation Features
String Puppets	**Kathputli**	**Rajasthan**	Carved from a single block of mango wood and dressed in vibrant medieval Rajasthani garments; manipulated with strings, while the puppeteer produces sharp whistling voices using a reed whistle called a *Boli*.
	Kundhei	**Odisha**	Made of lightweight wood with long flowing skirts and no articulated legs; movements are closely attuned to the rhythms of Odissi music.
	Gombeyatta	**Karnataka**	Highly stylized wooden puppets modeled directly upon the elaborate costumes, headdresses, and characters of **Yakshagana** theatre.
	Bommalattam	**Tamil Nadu**	Combines mechanisms of **both rod and string puppetry**; represents the largest, heaviest, and most mechanically complex puppets in India, operated via a cloth ring worn on the puppeteer's head.
Shadow Puppets	**Tholu Bommalata**	**Andhra Pradesh**	Translucent leather puppets painted in glowing vegetable colors on both sides; projected against a backlit white cloth screen.
	Togalu Gombeyatta	**Karnataka**	Small, delicate leather shadow figures depicting epic scenes, operated behind an illuminated white screen.
	Ravanachhaya	**Odisha**	Made from opaque deerskin; **casts purely black-and-white shadows** on the screen without color projections and has no articulated joints, producing dramatic silhouetted forms.
Glove Puppets	**Pavakoothu**	**Kerala**	Worn directly over the puppeteer’s hand; intricately modeled with carved wooden heads and painted costumes inspired directly by **Kathakali** makeup and crowns.
Rod Puppets	**Putul Nach**	**West Bengal**	Heavy wooden dolls sculpted with shoulder joints; manipulated from beneath the stage by puppeteers holding sturdy control rods.
	Yampuri	**Bihar**	Carved entirely from single pieces of wood without joints; specifically dramatizes moral tales set in the court of Yama, the God of Death.

10. Martial Arts of India

Martial Art Form	State of Origin	Key Weapons, Principles & Distinctive Features
Kalaripayattu	**Kerala**	Celebrated as the **oldest living martial art in the world** (mythologically attributed to Sage Parashurama); practiced within a sacred subterranean earthen arena (*Kalari*). Employs strikes, grappling, and traditional weapons including the deadly flexible whip-sword (**Urumi**), staff, and buckler.

Martial Art Form	State of Origin	Key Weapons, Principles & Distinctive Features
Silambam	**Tamil Nadu**	An ancient staff-fencing martial art referenced in Sangam literature such as the *Silappadikaram*; utilizes a 1.68-metre rapid-spinning **bamboo staff** (*Silambam*) to deflect attacks and strike vulnerable targets.
Thang-Ta & Sarit Sarak	**Manipur**	The traditional combat system of Meitei warriors; **Thang-Ta** emphasizes armed warfare (**Thang** = sword, **Ta** = spear), while **Sarit Sarak** comprises unarmed hand-to-hand combat and evasion.
Gatka	**Punjab**	Traditional Sikh martial art codified under the patronage of the sixth Sikh Guru, **Guru Hargobind Ji**; practitioners utilize wooden training swords (*Gatka*) and leather target shields, prominently demonstrated during the Hola Mohalla festival.
Pari-Khanda	**Bihar**	Created historically by Rajput warriors; utilizes the shield (**Pari**) and two-edged sword (**Khanda**); its footwork patterns and athletic steps form the foundational physical vocabulary of **Chhau dance**.
Thoda	**Himachal Pradesh**	A traditional martial sport rooted in **archery** that traces its lineage to the Mahabharata; practiced during Baisakhi in the Kullu and Shimla hills, where competing archers aim blunt arrows strictly at their opponents' legs below the knees.
Mallakhamb	**Madhya Pradesh & Maharashtra**	An extraordinary traditional gymnastic martial discipline in which athletes perform dynamic aerial yoga postures and acrobatic maneuvers on a vertical polished teak pole or a hanging cotton rope; declared the **State Sport of Madhya Pradesh**.
Musti-Yuddha	**Varanasi (Uttar Pradesh)**	Ancient traditional unarmed Indian pugilism and bare-knuckle boxing utilizing punches, elbow strikes, and grappling maneuvers.
Mardani Khel	**Maharashtra** (Kolhapur)	A historic Maratha armed martial art emphasizing agility, swordplay with the flexible gauntlet-sword (**Patta**), and defense using the bamboo staff (*Kathi*).
Kuttu Varisai	**Tamil Nadu**	Traditional Dravidian unarmed martial art focusing on rapid footwork, devastating animal-style strikes, and knowledge of vital pressure points (**Varma Kalai**).

11. Hindustani Classical Music Gharanas & Leading Exponents

Gharana	Founders & Historical Pioneers	Key Stylistic Characteristics & Aesthetics	Renowned Maestros & Legendary Exponents
Gwalior Gharana	**Nathan Pir Bakhsh**, **Hassu Khan**, **Haddu Khan**	Acknowledged as the **oldest and foundational Khayal gharana**; characterized by an unadorned, noble, open-throated singing style (*Aakaar*), balanced exposition of the raga, and systematic note expansion.	Vishnu Digambar Paluskar, Pt. Omkarnath Thakur, D.V. Paluskar, Malini Rajurkar, Neela Bhagwat
Agra Gharana	**Haji Sujan Khan**, **Khuda Bakhsh**; revitalized by **Ustad Faiyaz Khan**	Famously known as the **"Rangeela Gharana"**; marked by a robust, deep, resonant voice culture that masterfully infuses classical Khayal with ancient Dhrupad-Dhamar *Nom-Tom* alap elements.	Ustad Faiyaz Khan, Vilayat Hussain Khan, Shrikrishna Narayan Ratanjankar, Khadim Hussain Khan
Kirana Gharana	**Ustad Abdul Karim Khan**, **Ustad Abdul Wahid Khan** (originating from Kirana, Shamli district, UP)	Distinguished by deep emotional resonance, supreme tonal purity (*Sur*), and leisurely, contemplative note-by-note melodic evolution (**Vilambit Khayal**).	**Pt. Bhimsen Joshi**, Gangubai Hangal, Sawai Gandharva, Prabha Atre, Hirabai Barodekar

Gharana	Founders & Historical Pioneers	Key Stylistic Characteristics & Aesthetics	Renowned Maestros & Legendary Exponents
Jaipur-Atrauli Gharana	**Ustad Alladiya Khan**	Celebrated for complex, rare, and compound ragas (*Jod Ragas*); distinguished by intricate, spiral rhythmic phrasing (*Taans*) executed in an offbeat, asymmetrical swing across challenging talas.	**Kishori Amonkar**, Kesarbai Kerkar, Mogubai Kurdikar, Mallikarjun Mansur, Shruti Sadolikar
Patiala Gharana	**Ustad Fateh Ali Khan** and **Ustad Ali Bakhsh Khan** ("Alia-Fattu")	Known for dynamic, lightning-fast cascade passages (*Taans*), expressive emotional embellishments, and seamless mastery over both classical Khayal and romantic semiclassical **Thumri**.	**Ustad Bade Ghulam Ali Khan**, Begum Akhtar, Parveen Sultana, Jagjit Singh, Ajoy Chakrabarty
Banaras Gharana (Vocal & Instrumental)	**Pt. Ram Sahai** (Tabla pioneer), **Thakur Prasad** (Kathak pioneer)	Celebrated worldwide for its unparalleled mastery over the **Tabla**, **Sarangi**, and **Shehnai**, as well as soul-stirring semiclassical vocal forms including **Thumri, Dadra, Chaiti, and Kajri**.	**Ustad Bismillah Khan** (Shehnai — Bharat Ratna), **Pt. Kishan Maharaj** (Tabla), **Pt. Samta Prasad / Gudai Maharaj** (Tabla), **Girija Devi** (Queen of Thumri), Siddheshwari Devi, Rajan & Sajan Mishra